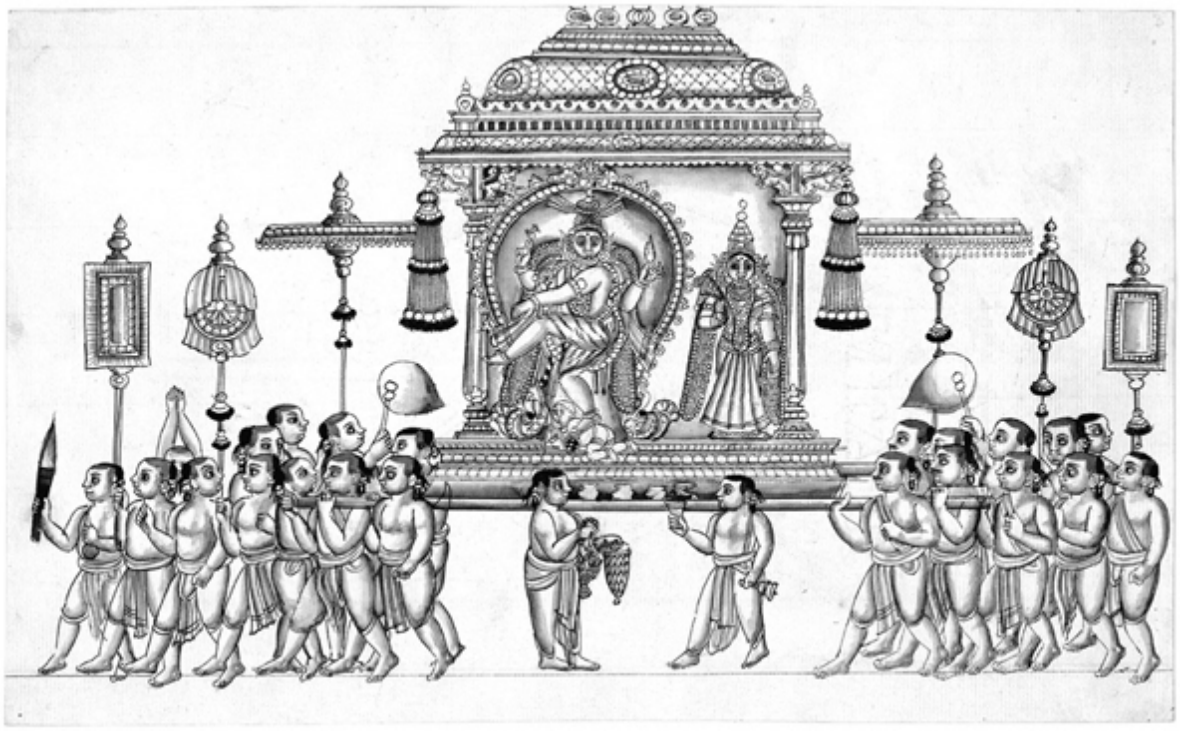
A panel from the rock-cut Shiva temple on Elephanta Island, showing an early carving of Shiva as Nataraja. Detail from a stereoscopic photograph by James Ricalton, 1903.



Dressed bronzes of Shiva Nataraja and his consort Shivakami carried in procession in a portable *mandapa*, or pillared pavilion, accompanied by priests bearing flowers and devotees carrying symbols of royalty in the form of parasols, fly-whisks and pennants. A pen and wash drawing probably from Trichy, c. 1820.

I made passing reference to the Early Chalukyas in Chapter 6 as enemies of the Pallavas. They first appeared in the middle of the sixth century to challenge the Brahmin Kadambas, who themselves have a claim to be founders of Karnataka as a distinct Kannada-speaking region with its own identity. These Chalukyas were most probably a hill tribe and they made a secure homeland for themselves in the mountains of the Western Ghats in an upper stretch of the Malapraha, one of the highest tributaries of the Krishna River, with their capital at Vatami (today Badami), where the town nestles under a wall of cliffs topped by a fortress. It was here on the steep escarpment between the town and